Algebraic and Differential Topology – Lecture Notes

Judith Brinkschulte

Winter Semester 2026/2027

Contents

Index **1**

1 Introduction **3**

2 Homotopy **5**

3 Covering Spaces **9**

3.1 Fundamental group of circles and applications 12

3.2 Fundamental groups of spheres and tori 15

This script was written by a student and is therefore prone to error. Please direct all typographical errors to the e-mail "hc75nigi@studserv.uni-leipzig.de". For content errors or questions to the content, please ask your lecturer directly.
This is the raw version of the script. Changes to the Layout will happen over time.

1 Introduction

Definition 1.1.
A topology on a set X is a collection τ of subsets of X such that:

(i) $\varnothing, X \in \tau$.

(ii) If $U_i \in \tau$ for all $i \in I$, then $\bigcup_{i\in I} U_i \in \tau$.

(iii) If $U_i \in \tau$ for all $i \in I$ where I is finite, then $\bigcap_{i\in I} U_i \in \tau$.

We call the pair (X, τ) a topological space. The elements of τ are called open sets.

Definition 1.2.
A **basis** for a topology on X is a collection $\mathcal{B}$ of subsets of X such that:

(i) $\forall x \in X$, $\exists B \in \mathcal{B}$ containing x.

(ii) If $x \in B_1 \cap B_2$ for some $B_1, B_2 \in \mathcal{B}$, then there is a basis element $B_3 \in \mathcal{B}$ such that $x \in B_3 \subseteq B_1 \cap B_2$.

$\mathcal{B}$ generates a topology τ on X as follows:
$U \in \tau$ if $\forall x \in U$, $\exists B \in \mathcal{B}$ such that $x \in B \subseteq U$.

Remark 1.3.
It is important that $B \in \mathcal{B}$ is a subset of U in the last statement. If we only required $x \in B \cap U$, we would run into problems. For example consider $X = \mathbb{R}$ and $U = \{0, 1\}$. We know that $\mathcal{B} = \{(a, b) : a, b \in \mathbb{R}, a < b\}$ is a basis for the standard topology on $\mathbb{R}$. Then for $x = 0$, we can choose $B = (-1, 1)$ and for $x = 1$, we can choose $B = (0, 2)$. This would mean that U is open, which should not be the case.

Example 1.4.

- (M, d) is a metric space. Then $\mathcal{B} = \{B_r(x) : x \in M, r > 0\}$ is a basis for the metric topology on M, where $B_r(x) = \{y \in M : d(x, y) < r\}$ is the open ball of radius r around x.
- X, Y topological spaces. The product topology on $X \times Y$ is generated by the basis $\mathcal{B} = \{U \times V : U \subseteq X, V \subseteq Y \text{ open}\}$.
- subspace topology: Let (X, τ) be a topological space, $S \subseteq X$. Then the subspace topology of S is $\tau_S = \{U \cap S : U \in \tau\}$.

Definition 1.5.
U is a neighbourhood of x if $\exists V$ open such that $x \in V \subseteq U$.

Definition 1.6.
Let X, Y be topological spaces.
A map $f : X \to Y$ is continuous if $\forall U \subseteq Y$ open, $f^{-1}(U)$ is open in X.
If f is a bijection and both f and f^{-1} are continuous, then f is called a homeomorphism. In this case, we say that X and Y are homeomorphic or topologically equivalent ($X \simeq Y$).

Example 1.7.

- $f : [0,1] \to \mathbb{S}^1$ given by $f(t) = (cos(2\pi t), sin(2\pi t))$.
  f is continuous and bijective but f^{-1} is not continuous.
  $f([0,1))$ is not open in $\mathbb{S}^1$.
- $\mathbb{R} \not\simeq \mathbb{R}^2$: Assume they are homeomorphic. Then there exists a homeomorphism $f : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}^2$ with $f(0) = (a,b)$. But $f|_{\mathbb{R}\setminus\{0\}} : \mathbb{R} \setminus \{0\} \to \mathbb{R}^2 \setminus \{(a,b)\}$ is a homeomorphism. But $\mathbb{R} \setminus \{0\}$ is not connected, while $\mathbb{R}^2 \setminus \{(a,b)\}$ is connected. This is a contradiction.
- $\mathbb{R}^2 \not\simeq \mathbb{R}^3$: Assume they are diffeomorphic. Then there exists a diffeomorphism $f : \mathbb{R}^2 \to \mathbb{R}^3$. Then $f \circ f^{-1} = id_{\mathbb{R}^3}, f^{-1} \circ f = id_{\mathbb{R}^2}$ so $Df_x Df_y^{-1} = I_3$ and $Df_y^{-1} Df_x = I_2$.

2 Homotopy

Definition 2.1.
Let X, Y be topological spaces (as always in this chapter) and $f, g : X \to Y$ be continuous maps. Then f is called **homotopic** to g if there exists a $F : X \times I \to Y$ continuous s.t. $F(x,0) = f(x)$ and $F(x,1) = g(x)$ for all $x \in X$. We write $f \simeq_F g$ and F is called a **homotopy** between f and g. If $f \simeq c$ where c is a constant map, then f is called null-homotopic.

Definition 2.2.
A continuous map $f : I \to X$ is called a path in X.
Two paths $f, g : I \to X$ are called **path homotopic** if they have the same start and end points, i.e. $f(0) = g(0)$ and $f(1) = g(1)$, and there exists a continuous map $F : I \times I \to X$ s.t. $F(x,0) = f(x)$, $F(x,1) = g(x)$ for all $x \in I$, and $F(0,t) = f(0) = g(0)$, $F(1,t) = f(1) = g(1)$ for all $t \in I$. We write $f \simeq_F g$.

Remark 2.3.
This is an equivalence relation:

(i) $f \simeq_F f$ with $F(x,t) = f(x)$ for all $x, t \in I$.

(ii) $f \simeq_F g \implies g \simeq_G f$ with $G(x,t) := F(x, 1-t)$.

(iii) $f \simeq_F g$, $g \simeq_G h \implies f \simeq_H h$ with $\begin{cases} H(x,t) = F(x,2t) & 0 \le t \le \frac{1}{2} \\ H(x,t) = G(x,2t-1) & \frac{1}{2} \le t \le 1 \end{cases}$

If f is a path then we call $[f]$ the path homotopy equivalence class of f.

Example 2.4.

- Any two continuous maps $f, g : X \to \mathbb{R}^2$ are homotopic with $F(x,t) = (1-t)f(x) + tg(x)$.
- Let $X = \mathbb{R}^2 \setminus \{(0,0)\}$ and let $f, g : I \to X$ be defined by $f(t) = e^{\pi i t}$ and $g(t) = e^{-\pi i t}$. Then f and g are not path homotopic in X. Proving this is not trivial. First, we state an equivalent problem which is slightly easier to prove. Instead of two paths, we try to show that the unit circle as a path $h(t) = e^{2\pi i t}$ is not path homotopic to a constant path (w.l.o.g. $(1,0)$).

Assume there is a path homotopy $F : I \times I \to X$ such that $F(x,0) = h(x)$ and $F(x,1) = (1,0)$. W.l.o.g. we may assume $F : I \times I \to \mathbb{S}^1$: if F' is a path homotopy, then $F := \frac{x}{|x|} \circ F'$ is one too, because $\frac{x}{|x|}$ is continuous on X.

From here on we use the covering map (which we will define later (3.2)) $p : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{S}^1$, $p(t) = e^{2\pi i t}$. By a lemma which we will prove later (3.10), F has a lift $\tilde{F}$, i.e. a continuous map $\tilde{F} : I \times I \to \mathbb{R}$ with $p \circ \tilde{F} = F$. We can normalize $\tilde{F}$ such that $\tilde{F}(0,0) = 0$.

Because $F(0,t) = F(1,t) = F(x,1) = (1,0)$ are all mapped to 1 (we use $\mathbb{R}^2 \cong \mathbb{C}$ for convenience) and $p^{-1}(1) = \mathbb{Z}$, the maps $\tilde{F}(0,t)$, $\tilde{F}(1,t)$ and $\tilde{F}(x,1)$ are continuous with values in $\mathbb{Z}$, and $\mathbb{Z}$ is discrete. Hence each of them is constant. Since consecutive edges share a corner, the three constants agree, and we get

$$\tilde{F}(0,0) = \tilde{F}(0,1) = \tilde{F}(1,1) = \tilde{F}(1,0) = 0.$$

We have now determined every edge except the bottom one. On the bottom edge, both $x \mapsto \tilde{F}(x,0)$ and $x \mapsto x$ are continuous lifts of h. We see that

$$p\big(\tilde{F}(x,0) - x\big) = \frac{h(x)}{h(x)} = 1,$$

so the difference lies in $\mathbb{Z}$. Since the difference is continuous on the connected set I, it is constant. At $x = 0$ the difference is 0, hence $\tilde{F}(x,0) = x$. But this is a contradiction, because $\tilde{F}(1,0) = 0 \neq 1$.

Definition 2.5.
Let f be a path in X from x_0 to x_1 and g be a path in X from x_1 to x_2. Then the **concatenation** of f and g is the path $f * g : I \to X$ defined by

$$f * g(x) = \begin{cases} f(2x) & 0 \le x \le \frac{1}{2} \\ g(2x-1) & \frac{1}{2} \le x \le 1 \end{cases}$$

This induces a product on the path homotopy equivalence classes: $[f]*[g] := [f*g]$.

Theorem 2.6.

(i) $[f] * ([g] * [h]) = ([f] * [g]) * [h]$

(ii) *Let $x \in X$ and e_x be the constant path at x. Let f be a path from x to y. Then $[e_x] * [f] = [f]$ and $[f] * [e_y] = [f]$.*

(iii) Let f be a path from x_0 to y. Then there exists an inverse path $\bar{f}$ from y to x_0 defined by $\bar{f}(x) = f(1-x)$. Then $[f] * [\bar{f}] = [e_{x_0}]$ and $[\bar{f}] * [f] = [e_y]$.

Proof.

(i) $[f] * ([g] * [h]) = [f * (g * h)] = [(f * g) * h] = ([f] * [g]) * [h]$ where the second equality follows from a reparametrization of the homotopy.

(ii) Let e_0 be the constant path at I and $id = i$ on I. We see that $i \simeq e_0 * i$. Then $f = f \circ i \simeq f \circ (e_0 * i) = (f \circ e_0) * (f \circ i) = e_{x_0} * f$. A similar argument shows $[f] * [e_y] = [f]$.

(iii) Let f be a path from x_0 to y. Then $\bar{f}(x) = f(1-x)$ is a path from y to x_0. It follows that $(f * \bar{f}(x)) = \begin{cases} f(2x) & 0 \le x \le \frac{1}{2} \\ f(2-2x) & \frac{1}{2} \le x \le 1 \end{cases} = f(t|1-2|x-\frac{1}{2}||)$. Let $F : I \times I \to X$ be defined by $F(x,t) = f(t|1-2|x-\frac{1}{2}||)$. Then $F(x,0) = f(0)$ and $F(x,1) = f(|1-2|x-\frac{1}{2}||)$. It follows that $(f * \bar{f}) \simeq_F e_{x_0}$. A similar argument shows $[\bar{f}] * [f] = [e_y]$.

□

Definition 2.7.
A **loop** based at $x_0 \in X$ is a path $f : I \to X$ with $f(0) = f(1) = x_0$.
$\pi_1(X, x_0)$ is the so called **fundamental group of X relative to** $x_0 (= \{[f] : f$ is a loop based at $x_0\})$. This is a group.

Example 2.8.
$\pi_1(\mathbb{R}^n, x_0) = 0$ for all $x_0 \in \mathbb{R}^n$. Also, $\pi_1(X, x_0) = 0$ for all $x_0 \in X$ if $X \subseteq \mathbb{R}^n$ is convex.

Question: Does $\pi_1(X, x_0)$ depend on the choice of x_0?

Definition 2.9.
Let f be a loop based at x_0. We define $\alpha : [0,1] \to X$ as a path from x_0 to x_1. It is easy to see that $\bar{\alpha} * f * \alpha$ is a loop based at x_1.
We define a map $\hat{\alpha} : \pi_1(X, x_0) \to \pi_1(X, x_1)$ by $\hat{\alpha}([f]) = [\bar{\alpha} * f * \alpha]$.

Theorem 2.10.
$\hat{\alpha}$ is a group isomorphism.

Proof.
Let f, g be loops based at x_0. Then $\hat{\alpha}([f] * [g]) = \hat{\alpha}([f * g]) = [\bar{\alpha} * (f * g) * \alpha] = [\bar{\alpha} * f * e_{x_1} * g * \alpha] = [\bar{\alpha} * f * (\alpha * \bar{\alpha}) * g * \alpha] = [\bar{\alpha} * f * \alpha] * [\bar{\alpha} * g * \alpha] = \hat{\alpha}([f]) * \hat{\alpha}([g])$.
If $\beta = \bar{\alpha}$, then $\hat{\beta} = \hat{\alpha}^{-1}$. Because $\hat{\alpha}$ is a homomorphism and it has an inverse, it is a group isomorphism. □

Corollary 2.11.
Let X be path connected. Then $\pi_1(X, x_0) \cong \pi_1(X, x_1)$ for all $x_0, x_1 \in X$.

Definition 2.12.
X is called **simply connected** if it is path connected and $\pi_1(X, x_0) = 0$ for some (and hence all) $x_0 \in X$.

Theorem 2.13.
Let $h : (X, x_0) \to (Y, y_0)$ be a continuous map with $h(x_0) = y_0$. Then h induces a homomorphism $h_* : \pi_1(X, x_0) \to \pi_1(Y, y_0)$ with $h_*([f]) = [h \circ f]$ for all $[f] \in \pi_1(X, x_0)$.

Proof.
h_* is well defined: if $f \simeq g$ then $h \circ f \simeq h \circ g$.
h_* is a homomorphism: let f, g be loops based at x_0. Then $h_*([f] * [g]) = h_*([f * g]) = [h \circ (f * g)] = [h \circ f * h \circ g] = [h \circ f] * [h \circ g] = h_*([f]) * h_*([g])$. □

Theorem 2.14.
If h is a homeomorphism then h_* is an isomorphism.

Proof.
Let $k = h^{-1}$. Then $k_* \circ h_* = (k \circ h)_* = id_* = id$. □

3 Covering Spaces

Definition 3.1.
Let $p : E \to B$ be a continuous, surjective map and let $U \subseteq B$ be an open set. We say U is **evenly covered by p** if $p^{-1}(U)$ is the disjoint union of open sets V_α in E such that $p|_{V_\alpha}$ is a homeomorphism from V_α onto U for all α.
We say $\{V_\alpha\}_{\alpha \in A}$ is a partition of p^{-1} into slices.

Definition 3.2.
Let $p : E \to B$ be a continuous, surjective map. If every $b \in B$ has a neighbourhood U that is evenly covered by p, then p is called a **covering map**, B is called the **base of the covering** and E is the **covering Space of** B.
We call $p^{-1}(x)$ a fiber over x.

Remark 3.3.

- $\forall b \in B, p^{-1}(b)$ is discrete in E: each slice V_α is open in E and intersects $p^{-1}(b)$ in a single point.
- Covering maps are open: Let $V \subseteq E$ be open. Take $x \in p(V)$. Choose a neighbourhood U of x in B which is evenly covered by p. Let $\{V_\alpha\}$ be the slices of $p^{-1}(U)$ and choose $y \in V$ such that $p(y) = x$ and β such that $y \in V_\beta$. We know that $V \cap V_\beta$ is open in E, hence open in V_β. Now we know that $p|_{V_\beta} : V_\beta \to U$ is a homeomorphism, hence $p(V \cap V_\beta)$ is open in U, hence open in B and it is still a neighbourhood of x in $p(V)$.

Example 3.4.

- Let X be a topological space and $E = X \times \{1, ..., n\}$. Then $p : E \to X$ given by $p(x, i) = x$ is a covering map.
- $p : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{S}^1$ given by $p(x) = (\cos(2\pi x), \sin(2\pi x))$ is a covering map. For example $p^{-1}(U) = \{x \in \mathbb{R} : \cos(2\pi x) > 0\} = \bigcup_{n \in \mathbb{Z}} (n - \frac{1}{4}, n + \frac{1}{4})$, so we see that $V_n = (n - \frac{1}{4}, n + \frac{1}{4})$ are disjoint open sets. Because $\sin(2\pi x)$ is strictly monoton on $\bar{V_n}$ we get that $p|_{\bar{V_n}} : \bar{V_n} \to \bar{U}$ is bijective and also homeomorphic.

- Conversely $p : \mathbb{R}^+ \to \mathbb{S}^1$ with the same definition is **NOT** a covering map (despite being a surjective, continuous, local homeomorphism). This is due to $(1,0)$ not having a neighbourhood which is evenly covered by p so $p : V_n \to U$ is a homeomorphism for all $n \neq 0$.

Theorem 3.5.
Let $p : E \to B$ and $p' : E' \to B'$ be two covering maps. Then $p \times p' : E \times E' \to B \times B'$ is again a covering map.

Proof.
Let $b \in B, b' \in B'$ and choose U, U' to be the, by p and p' evenly covered neighbourhoods of b and b' respectively. So we get $p^{-1}(U) = \bigcup_\alpha V_\alpha$ and $p'^{-1}(U') = \bigcup_\beta V'_\beta$. It follows that $(p \times p')^{-1}(U \times U') = (\bigcup_{\alpha,\beta} V_\alpha \times V'_\beta)$ which shows that $p \times p'$ is indeed a covering map. □

Example 3.6.
- $T = \mathbb{S}^1 \times \mathbb{S}^1$ is the torus which has by the preciding theorem 3.5 a covering map in $p \times p : \mathbb{R} \times \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{S}^1 \times \mathbb{S}^1$ given by $(s,t) \to (\cos(2\pi s), \sin(2\pi s), \cos(2\pi t), \sin(2\pi t))$.
- Let $p \times p$ be as above and let $b_0 = p(0) = (1,0)$. We also define $B_0 := (\mathbb{S}^1 \times \{b_0\}) \cup (\{b_0\} \times \mathbb{S}^1)$ and $E_0 := (p \times p)^{-1}(B_0) = (\mathbb{R} \times \mathbb{Z}) \cup (\mathbb{Z} \times \mathbb{R})$. Then $p \times p : E_0 \to B_0$ is a covering map.

Definition 3.7.
Let $p : E \to B$ and $f : X \to B$ be a continuous map with E, B, X being topological spaces and p being a covering map. A **lifting** of f is a map $\tilde{f} : X \to E$ s.t. $p \circ \tilde{f} = f$

Example 3.8.
We choose $p : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{S}^1$ as before and $f : [0,1] \to \mathbb{S}^1$ given by $f(t) = (\cos(\pi t), \sin(\pi t))$. Then f lifts to $\tilde{f} : [0,1] \to \mathbb{R}$, $t \to \frac{1}{2}t$. If we look at $h : [0,1] \to \mathbb{S}^1$ given by $h(t) = (\cos(4\pi t), \sin(4\pi t))$ we see that it lifts to $\tilde{h}(s) = 2s$.

Lemma 3.9.
Let $p : E \to B$ be again a covering map, $b_0 \in B$ and $p(e_0) = b_0$. Any path $f : [0,1] \to B$ beginning at b_0 has a unique lifting to a path $\tilde{f}$ beginning at e_0.

Proof.
Let B be covered by finitley many open sets U which in turn are evenly covered by the map p (possible because $B = f([0,1])$, f is continuous, $[0,1]$ is compact and covered by the open sets $f^{-1}(U)$). Now we may choose a subdivision $0 = s_0 < s_1 < ... < s_n = 1$ of $[0,1]$ such that $f([s_i, s_{i+1}]) \subseteq U$.
Set $\tilde{f}(0) = e_0$. Suppose $\tilde{f}$ is defined for $0 \leq s \leq s_i$. We define $\tilde{f}$ on $[s_i, s_{i+1}]$ as follows:
By construction $f([s_i, s_{i+1}])$ lies in some open U which is evenly covered by p with $p^{-1}(U) = \bigcup_\alpha V_\alpha$ and $p : V_\alpha \to U$ is homeomorphic for all α. We choose β such that $\tilde{f}(s_i) \in V_\beta$ and set $\tilde{f}(s) = (p|_{V_\beta}^{-1} \circ f(s))$. Now it follows that $\tilde{f}$ is continuous and $p \circ \tilde{f} = f$ by definition.
Uniqueness: Let $\tilde{f}'$ be another lifting with $\tilde{f}'(0) = e_0$. Suppose $\tilde{f}(s) = \tilde{f}'(s) \quad \forall 0 \leq s \leq s_i$ and define V_β as before. $\tilde{f}'([s_i, s_{i+1}])$ is connected, hence it must lie entirely in V_β. Thus for $s \in [s_i, s_{i+1}]$, $\tilde{f}'(s)$ equals to some point $y \in V_\beta$ such that $p(\tilde{f}'(s)) = f(s)$ with $y \in p^{-1}(f(s))$. But there is only one such point, namely $\tilde{f}(s) \implies \tilde{f}'(s) = \tilde{f}(s)$. □

Lemma 3.10.
Let $p : E \to B$ be a covering map and $p(e_0) = b_0$. Let $F : [0,1] \times [0,1] \to B$ be a continuous map with $F(0,0) = b_0$. Then there exists a unique lifting $\tilde{F} : [0,1] \times [0,1] \to E$ such that $\tilde{F}(0,0) = e_0$. If F is a path homotopy, then so is $\tilde{F}$.

Proof.
We only provied a sketch here because this proof is very similar to the proof of the preceeding lemma 3.9. By set lemma we get that F lifts to $I \times \{0\}$ and $\{0\} \times I$. Now we impose two different subdivisions s_n and t_m as before. If F is a path homotopy, then $F(\{0\} \times I) = b_0$ and because $\tilde{F}$ is a lifting, it follows that $\tilde{F}(\{0\} \times I) \subseteq p^{-1}(b_0)$ which is discrete as we discussed. Because $\{0\} \times I$ is connected, it follows that $\tilde{F}(\{0\} \times I)$ is connected, hence $\tilde{F}(\{0\} \times I)$ is a one-point set. The same holds for $\tilde{F}(I \times \{0\})$. □

Theorem 3.11.
Let $p : E \to B$ be a covering map with $p(e_0) = b_0$. Let f, g be two paths in B from b_0 to b_1 and let $\tilde{f}, \tilde{g}$ be the liftings of f, g starting at e_0. If $f \simeq g$, then $\tilde{f}$ and $\tilde{g}$ end and start at the same point, and $\tilde{f} \simeq \tilde{g}$.

Proof.
Let $F : I \times I \to B$ be the path homotopy between f, g so $F(0,0) = b_0$. By lemma 3.10

$\tilde{F}$ is a lifting of F to E with $\tilde{F}(0,0) = e_0$ and it is also a path homotopy. We know therefore that $\tilde{F}(\{0\} \times I) = \{e_0\}$ and $\tilde{F}(\{0\} \times I) = \{e_1\}$. $\tilde{F}|_{I\times\{0\}}$ is a path starting at e_0 and the lifting of $F|_{I\times\{0\}}$. By the uniqueness of liftings $\tilde{F}(s,0) = \tilde{f}(s)$. The same argument gives $\tilde{F}(s,1) = \tilde{g}(s)$ which implies that $\tilde{f}(1) = \tilde{g}(1) = e_1$. Therefore $\tilde{f} \simeq_{\tilde{F}} \tilde{g}$. □

Definition 3.12.
Let $p : E \to B$ be a covering map with $p(e_0) = b_0$. Choose $[f] \in \pi_1(B, b_0)$. Let $\tilde{f}$ be the lifting of f such that $\tilde{f}(0) = e_0$. $\phi : \pi_1(B, b_0) \to p^{-1}(b_0) = E_{b_0}$ defined by $\phi([f]) := \tilde{f}(1)$. This ϕ is well defined due to the theorem 3.11.

Theorem 3.13.
In the same setup as in the definition 3.12: If E is path-connected then ϕ is surjective.
If E is simply connected then ϕ is bijective.

Proof.
First, let E be path-connected and $e_1 \in p^{-1}(b_0)$. $\tilde{f}$ is a path in E from e_0 to e_1. $f := p \circ \tilde{f}$ is a loop in B based at b_0. Then $\phi([f]) = \tilde{f}(1) = e_1 \implies \phi$ is surjective.
Now let E be simply connected and let $[f], [g]$ such that $\phi([f]) = \phi([g])$. Then $\tilde{f}, \tilde{g}$ are liftings that start in e_0. It follows that $\tilde{f}(1) = \tilde{g}(1)$, hence $\tilde{f} \simeq_{\tilde{F}} \tilde{g} \implies f \simeq_{p\circ\tilde{F}} g$ □

3.1 Fundamental group of circles and applications

Theorem 3.14.
$\pi_1(\mathbb{S}^1) \simeq \mathbb{Z}$

Proof.
Let $b_0 = (1,0), e_0 = 0$ and $p : \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{S}^1$ be the standard covering.
We need to show that $\phi : \pi_1(\mathbb{S}^1, b_0) \to p^{-1}(b_0) = \mathbb{Z}$ (from definition 3.12) is a homomorphism.
For that, let $[f], [g] \in \pi_1(\mathbb{S}^1, b_0)$ and let $\tilde{f}, \tilde{g}$ be liftings starting at 0 and define $n := \tilde{f}(1), m := \tilde{g}(1)$ ($n \in \mathbb{Z}$ because $p(\tilde{f}(1)) = f(1) = b_0$ so $\tilde{f}(1) \in p^{-1}(b_0) = \mathbb{Z}$).
Now we define $\tilde{g}'(s) := n + \tilde{g}(s)$ which is a path in $\mathbb{R}$. We have that $\forall x \in \mathbb{R}, n \in \mathbb{Z} :$ $p(x + n) = p(x) \implies \tilde{g}'(s)$ is the lifting of g starting at n. It follows that $\tilde{f} * \tilde{g}'$ is well defined and a lifting of $f * g$ starting at 0. Since $\tilde{f} * \tilde{g}'(1) = n + m$, we have $\phi([f] * [g]) = n + m = \phi([f]) + \phi([g])$. □

Definition 3.15.
Let $A \subseteq X$. A **retraction** of X onto A is a continuous map $r : X \to A$ such that $r|_A = id_A$. A is then called **retract** of X.

Example 3.16.
$r : \mathbb{R}^2 \setminus \{(0,0)\} \to \mathbb{S}^1$ with $r(x) = \frac{x}{\|x\|}$

Definition 3.17.
For any continuous map $\varphi : (X, x_0) \to (Y, y_0)$ the **induced homomorphism** (or induced homomorphism of fundamental groups) is $\varphi_* : \pi_1(X, x_0) \to \pi_1(Y, y_0)$ given by $\varphi_*([f]) = [\varphi \circ f]$.

Lemma 3.18.
If $r : X \to A$ is a retraction, then the homomorphism of fundamental groups induced by the inclusion $j : A \to X$ is injective.

Proof.
We know $r \circ j = id_A \implies r_* \circ j_* = (r \circ j)_* = (id_A)_* = id$ with $j_*([f]) = [j \circ f]$.
Now, because j_* has a left inverse we get that it is also injective. □

Theorem 3.19.
There is no retraction $r : D^2 \to \mathbb{S}^1$ with $D^2 = \{x \in \mathbb{R}^2 | \|x\| \leq 1\}$.

Proof.
Assume $\mathbb{S}^1$ is a retract of D^2 and let $j : \mathbb{S}^1 \to D^2$ be the inclusen.
Then $j_* : \pi_1(\mathbb{S}^1, x_0) \to \pi_1(D^2, x_0)$ is injective.
But this is a contradiction because $\pi_1(\mathbb{S}^1, x_0) = \mathbb{Z}$ and $\pi_1(D^2, x_0) = 0$. □

Lemma 3.20.
Let $h : \mathbb{S}^1 \to X$ be continuous. The following are equivalent:
(i) h is nullhomotopic

(ii) h extends to a continuous map $\tilde{h} : D^2 \to X$

(iii) $h_* = 0$ *(h induces the trivial homomorphism on the fundamental groups)*

Proof.
$(i) \implies (ii)$
$(i) \implies \exists H : \mathbb{S}^1 \times I \to X$ homotopy between h and a constant path.
Now define $\pi : \mathbb{S}^1 \times I \to D^2$ as $\pi(x,t) = (1-t)x$. This function is continuous, closed and surjective.
π collapses $\mathbb{S}^1 \times \{1\}$ to $(0,0)$ and is injective everywhere else.
We know that H is constant on $\mathbb{S}^1 \times 1 \implies H \circ \pi^{-1}$ is well-defined, so this gives a continuous extension $\tilde{h}$ of h to D^2.
$(ii) \implies (iii)$
Let $\tilde{h}$ be the continuous extension of h given by (ii) and let $j : \mathbb{S}^1 \to D^2$ be the inclusion map.
$h = \tilde{h} \circ j \implies h_* = \tilde{h}_* \circ j_*$ and $j_* : \pi_1(\mathbb{S}^1, x_0) \to \pi_1(D^2, x_0) = 0 \implies j_* = 0 \implies h_* = 0$.
$(iii) \implies (i)$
$\pi_1(\mathbb{S}^1, b_0)$ is generated by $[p|_I]$, $p_0 = p|_I$ and we define $x_0 := h(b_0)$.
(iii) gives $0 = h_*[p_0] = [h \circ p_0]$, hence there is a homotopy F in X between $h \circ p_0$ and e_{x_0} with $F(\{0\} \times I) = \{x_0\}, F(\{1\} \times I) = \{x_0\}$.
It follows that $(s,t) \to F(p_0^{-1}(s), t)$ is well-defined on $\mathbb{S}^1 \times I$ and defines a homotopy between h and e_{x_0}. □

Corollary 3.21.
The inclusion $j : \mathbb{S}^1 \to \mathbb{R}^2 \setminus \{(0,0)\}$ is not nullhomotopic and the identity $i : \mathbb{S}^1 \to \mathbb{S}^1$ is not nullhomotopic too.

Proof.

- Let $r : \mathbb{R}^2 \setminus \{(0,0)\} \to \mathbb{S}^1$ given by $x \to \frac{x}{\|x\|}$ be a retraction.
- It follows that j_* is injective hence non trivial so by lemma 3.20 j is not nullhomotopic.
- Let i be the identity on $\mathbb{S}^1 \implies I_* \neq 0 \implies i$ is not nullhomotopic.

□

Definition 3.22.
A **vectorfield** on D^2 is a pair $(x, V(x))$ with $x \in D^2$ and $V(x) \in \mathbb{R}^2$ where V :

$D^2 \to \mathbb{R}^2$ is continuous.
V points directly inward at x if $V(x) = \alpha x$ with $\alpha < 0$ and directly outward if $\alpha > 0$.

Theorem 3.23.
Given a ***nonvanishing*** *vectorfield V on D^2, there exists a point on $\mathbb{S}^1$ where V points directly outward and one where V points directly inward.*

Proof.
$V : D^2 \to \mathbb{R}^2 \setminus \{(0,0)\}$ is continuous.
Assume that $V(x)$ does not point directly inward $\forall x \in \mathbb{S}^1$.
We define $w := V|_{\mathbb{S}^1} : \mathbb{S}^1 \to \mathbb{R}^2 \setminus \{(0,0)\}$ which is nullhomotopic (Lemma 3.20 (ii)).
But w is homotopic to the inclusion $j : \mathbb{S}^1 \to \mathbb{R}^2 \setminus \{(0,0)\}$ which we show by the following means.
So lets define $F(x,t) = tx + (1-t)w(x)$ which is continuous for $x \in \mathbb{S}^1$ and we have $F(x,0) = w(x) \neq 0$, $F(x,1) = x \neq 0$ If $F(x,t) = 0$ for some $t \in (0,1)$,
then $w(x) = \frac{-tx}{1-t} = -\frac{t}{1-t}x$ points directly inward.
Hence $F(x,t) \neq 0$ for $x \in \mathbb{S}^1, t \in I \implies F$ is a homotopy between w and j in $\mathbb{R}^2 \setminus \{(0,0)\} \implies j$ is nullhomotopic ↯
If we replace V by $-V$ we get a point in $\mathbb{S}^1$, where V points directly outward. □

Theorem 3.24 (Brenwer fixed point theorem)**.**
If $f : D^2 \to D^2$ is continuous, then it has at least one fixed point.

Proof.
By contradiction, assume $\forall x \in D^2 : f(x) \neq x$. Then $V(x) := f(x) - x$ is a non vanishing vectorfield on D^2. V cannot point directly outward at some $x \in \mathbb{S}^1$:
$V(x) = \alpha x$ with $\alpha > 0 \implies f(x) = x + \alpha x = (1+\alpha)x \notin D^2$ ↯ □

3.2 Fundamental groups of spheres and tori

Index

concatenation, 6
continuous function, 4
covering map, 9

fundamental group, 7

homotopic, 5
homotopy, 5

lifting, 10
loop, 7

neighbourhood, 4

path homotopic, 5

retraction, 13

simply connected, 8

topological base, 3
topology, 3

vectorfield, 14